

Fixing Comma Splices — 9th Grade, 30 Minutes

Diagnose & Fix — Comma Splices

The Cover Test: Cover everything after the comma. Complete sentence? Cover everything before. Complete sentence? You have a splice. Fix it with a conjunction, a semicolon, or a period.

Exercise 1 — Fix it any way you like

The new phone costs over a thousand dollars, most students can't afford it.

Your fix:

Exercise 2 — Fix it with a conjunction

Climate change affects coastal cities, many are investing in flood barriers.

Your fix (add *and*, *but*, *so*, or *yet* after the comma):

Exercise 3 — Fix it with a semicolon

He wanted to try out for the team, he was nervous about the competition.

Your fix (replace the comma with a semicolon):

Exercise 4 — Write your own

Write one sentence that contains two independent clauses correctly joined with a comma and a conjunction.

Transfer — Find it in your own writing

Look back at your class starter. Copy one sentence below that is (or could be) a comma splice. Then fix it.

Original sentence:

Your fix:

Which method did you use? Circle one: **conjunction** **semicolon** **period**

Fixing Comma Splices

Slides — 11 slides · 25 min · English 9

1. Fixing Comma Splices · 1 min

One small fix that changes how your writing sounds

Notes: Let the starter wrap up. Tell students: 'In the next ten minutes you are going to learn to spot and fix one of the most common errors in student writing — and it takes about five seconds once you know it.'

2. Here is the problem · 1 min

The album dropped at midnight, fans crashed the streaming servers.

Notes: Read it aloud. Ask: 'Does anything feel off?' Wait 10 seconds. Students may say it sounds rushed or run-on. Do not name the error yet — let them describe the feeling first.

3. What is a comma splice? · 2 min

A comma splice happens when two complete sentences are joined with only a comma. Commas are useful — but not strong enough to hold two full sentences together.

Notes: Write 'independent clause' on the board. Ask: 'What makes a sentence complete?' (subject + verb + complete thought). The comma splice problem is that the comma is doing a job it cannot do alone.

4. The Cover Test · 2 min

Cover everything after the comma. Complete sentence? Cover everything before. Complete sentence? You have a splice.

Notes: Model with the album sentence on the board. Cover 'fans crashed the streaming servers' — complete sentence. Cover 'The album dropped at midnight' — complete sentence. Two complete sentences, one comma. That is the splice.

5. Three ways to fix it · 1 min

- Add a conjunction: , and / , but / , so / , yet
- Swap the comma for a semicolon: ;
- Split into two sentences: .

Notes: Tell students they will use all three today. Stress that none is 'better' — the choice depends on how closely the ideas are related and what rhythm they want.

6. Fix 1 — Add a conjunction · 1 min

Splice — The album dropped at midnight, fans crashed the streaming servers.

Fixed — The album dropped at midnight, and fans crashed the streaming servers.

Notes: Ask: 'Why 'and' and not 'but'?' Let students argue it. The ideas are additive, not contrasting — 'and' fits. This is the move that teaches them to think about meaning, not just mechanics.

7. Fix 2 — Semicolon · 1 min

Splice — The coach called a timeout, the players were exhausted.

Fixed — The coach called a timeout; the players were exhausted.

Notes: Ask: 'When does a semicolon feel right?' The ideas are closely linked — cause and effect implied. A period would work too, but the semicolon signals the connection. Let students weigh in.

8. Fix 3 — Period · 1 min

Splice — I finished my essay early, I decided to revise it one more time.

Fixed — I finished my essay early. I decided to revise it one more time.

Notes: Ask: 'Is the period always the boring choice?' No — sometimes two short punchy sentences hit harder than one long one. Writers use this on purpose. The fix is also the style.

9. Your turn — Diagnose & Fix handout · 10 min

- Do Exercise 1 together as a class.
- Complete Exercises 2 and 3 on your own — use a different fix for each.
- Write your own correctly joined sentence for Exercise 4.
- Then open Yawp and complete the practice set.

Notes: Circulate during independent work. Watch for the half-fix: students who add a comma but forget the conjunction, or who write 'however' after a comma (that is still a splice). Flag those two errors for the debrief.

10. Find it in your own writing · 3 min

Look back at your class starter. Find one sentence that could be a comma splice. Fix it in the margin. No sentence to fix? Write a new one and join it correctly.

Notes: Give 2 minutes of quiet time, then cold-call two or three students to read their original and their repair. Ask the class: 'Which fix did they use? Could they have chosen a different one?'

11. Exit ticket · 2 min

Open the exit ticket in Yawp before you go.

Notes: Students should have 3 minutes. While they write, scan the handouts for the half-fix errors you flagged during practice — those are tomorrow's opening move if several students share the same one.

Exit ticket: what a comma splice is and how to fix it

In your own words, explain what a comma splice is and how to fix it. Write it the way you would explain it to someone who missed class today — not the definition you were given, but what you actually understand it to mean.

Write as much as you can, and go further than your first sentence — the more you explain your thinking, the more this is worth. Don't worry about polish. This is about what you understand, not how neatly you say it.